

Permissive Working — Revision Guide

Module 3 — Permissive Working & Working of Single Lines | DC63 Driver Plan, Week 6 (22-26 June 2026)

Based on GERT8000-TW1 §20 and the RS521 Signalling Handbook, cross-referenced to the classroom session notes (which name RS521 and TW1 as the required source documents for this topic).

1. What Is Permissive Working?

Permissive working allows a second train to be signalled onto a running line that is already occupied, so that more than one train at a time can be on the same line in a:

- block section
- signal section
- dead-end platform line.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.1

2. Authority For Permissive Working

A permissive movement must only be made where authorised in the Sectional Appendix.

Exception: a shunting movement may be made onto a portion of line that is already occupied, even though permissive working is not authorised there, as long as it is for the purpose of attaching, detaching, or removing vehicles.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.2

3. Signals That Authorise Entry Into An Occupied Section

A movement into an occupied section can be authorised using:

- a position-light signal associated with a main aspect, or
- a semaphore subsidiary signal.

RS521 §2.7 / §3.4

Semaphore subsidiary signals (RS521 §3.4)

Always positioned below the main semaphore arm, on the same post. Normal position (arm horizontal; red, white, or no light) means 'obey the main arm'. When cleared (arm at 45°, or green light), it authorises the driver to pass the main arm at danger and proceed at caution towards the next train, signal or buffer stop, prepared to stop short of any obstruction.

Where the subsidiary also shows a letter:

- 'C' (Calling-on) — proceed at caution towards the next train, signal or buffer stop, prepared to stop short of any obstruction.
- 'S' (Shunt-ahead) — proceed for shunting purposes only.

RS521 §3.4

Position-light signals associated with a main aspect (RS521 §2.7)

Normally positioned below the main aspect, often on the same post. Normal (unlit) aspect means 'obey the main signal'. Two white lights at 45° authorises the driver to proceed at caution towards the next train, signal or buffer stop, prepared to stop short of any obstruction.

RS521 §2.7

4. Proceeding At Caution / Stopping Distance

When proceeding towards another train which is at a stand, the driver must approach at caution and stop the train at least 2 metres (6 feet 6 inches) short of the train in front.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.3

Classroom session notes add: when entering an occupied platform — particularly where the platform is curved or visibility is poor — travel at a speed that allows the train to stop safely within the distance seen to be clear. Control speed carefully for a smooth, gradual stop, and reduce speed earlier where there is a risk of low railhead adhesion.

Classroom PPTX (Permissive Working), slides 5-6

5. Following Another Train On A Permissive-Worked Line

When it is permitted to drive a train towards the rear of another train which is moving forward, the driver must:

- proceed at caution
- keep sufficient distance from the train in front to prevent colliding with it in case it stops
- not pass a signal which has been cleared for the train in front until that signal has been returned to danger and then cleared again.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.4

6. Setting-Back Movements Where Permissive Working Is Authorised

Once a train has come to a stand, no movement may be made (other than for coupling or uncoupling) unless one of the following applies:

- a signal is cleared for the movement
- the movement is authorised by the signalling system
- the movement is authorised by the signaller.

If the movement was made on the signaller's authority, the driver must tell the signaller when it has been completed.

A setting-back movement made when coupling or uncoupling must not be greater than 600 mm (2 feet). If a greater distance is needed, the signaller's authority must be obtained.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.5

7. Emergency Permissive Working

A permissive movement can also be made when the signaller tells the driver that, in an emergency situation on a TCB or ERTMS line, the train is authorised to enter an occupied section to use a station platform.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.6

8. 'OFF' Indicators At Permissive Platforms — Important Caution

An 'OFF' indication does NOT always mean the line ahead is clear — the signal it applies to may have been cleared for another train already standing ahead in the same platform. (On an ERTMS line without lineside signals, the same caution applies where a route has been set.)

On a bi-directional platform line, the 'OFF' indication may be accompanied by an 'UP' or 'DN' indication showing which route has been set.

RS521 §5.8

9. Risk Awareness — Stopping In The Correct Position

Classroom session notes highlight the following risks of not stopping correctly in an occupied/permissive platform:

- Stopping short: the rear of the train may not be along the platform edge — risk of death or serious injury if doors are opened in this position.
- Overrunning the correct position: may require a setting-back movement (needing authority) or drawing forward, causing delay — particularly difficult once passenger loading/unloading has begun.
- Bi-directional permissive platforms increase the risk of conflicting movements: only move once you have a clear understanding of how your movement will be authorised, and stop immediately if unsure or if you notice a conflicting movement.

Classroom PPTX (Permissive Working), slides 9-11

10. Other Permissive-Related Rules In TW1

If a train is stopped incorrectly at a platform and there is any doubt whether someone has fallen from the train, the driver must get the signaller's permission before making any of the following:

- a wrong-direction movement
- a movement towards a signal at danger
- any movement on a permissive platform line.

GERT8000-TW1 §39.1

Where permissive working is authorised, before a controlled test stop is arranged for low rail-adhesion conditions, it must be confirmed that the platform line is clear.

GERT8000-TW1 §28.3

Quick Reference

Item	Value	Reference
Minimum stopping distance behind a train at a stand	2 metres (6 ft 6 in)	TW1 §20.3
Setting-back limit for coupling/uncoupling without signaller authority	600 mm (2 ft)	TW1 §20.5
Calling-on subsidiary signal letter	'C'	RS521 §3.4
Shunt-ahead subsidiary signal letter	'S'	RS521 §3.4
Position-light proceed indication	Two white lights at 45°	RS521 §2.7

Revision Questions

1. What does permissive working allow?

Answer: It allows a second train to be signalled onto a running line that is already occupied, so more than one train at a time can be on the same line in a block section, signal section, or dead-end platform line.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.1

2. Where must a permissive movement be authorised?

Answer: A permissive movement must only be made where authorised in the Sectional Appendix.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.2

3. Is there an exception to needing Sectional Appendix authority for a movement onto an occupied line?

Answer: Yes — a shunting movement may be made onto a portion of line that is already occupied, even though permissive working is not authorised there, as long as it is for attaching, detaching, or removing vehicles.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.2

4. What two types of signal can authorise a movement into an occupied section?

Answer: A position-light signal associated with a main aspect, or a semaphore subsidiary signal.

RS521 §2.7 / §3.4

5. Where is a semaphore subsidiary signal positioned?

Answer: Always positioned below the main semaphore arm, on the same post.

RS521 §3.4

6. What does the normal position of a semaphore subsidiary signal mean?

Answer: Arm horizontal, showing red, white, or no light — it means 'obey the main arm'.

RS521 §3.4

7. What does a cleared semaphore subsidiary signal authorise?

Answer: When cleared (arm at 45°, or green light), it authorises the driver to pass the main arm at danger and proceed at caution towards the next train, signal or buffer stop, prepared to stop short of any obstruction.

RS521 §3.4

8. What does a 'C' on a subsidiary signal mean?

Answer: Calling-on — proceed at caution towards the next train, signal or buffer stop, prepared to stop short of any obstruction.

RS521 §3.4

9. What does an 'S' on a subsidiary signal mean?

Answer: Shunt-ahead — proceed for shunting purposes only.

RS521 §3.4

10. Where is a position-light signal associated with a main aspect normally positioned?

Answer: Normally positioned below the main aspect, often on the same post.

RS521 §2.7

11. What does two white lights at 45° on a position-light signal mean?

Answer: It authorises the driver to proceed at caution towards the next train, signal or buffer stop, prepared to stop short of any obstruction.

RS521 §2.7

12. What is the minimum distance a driver must stop short of a train at a stand when proceeding at caution?

Answer: At least 2 metres (6 feet 6 inches) short of the train in front.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.3

13. What classroom guidance applies when entering an occupied platform, especially if curved or visibility is poor?

Answer: Travel at a speed that allows the train to stop safely within the distance seen to be clear; control speed for a smooth, gradual stop; reduce speed earlier where there is a risk of low railhead adhesion.

Classroom PPTX (Permissive Working), slides 5-6

14. When following another train on a permissive-worked line, what three things must the driver do?

Answer: Proceed at caution; keep sufficient distance from the train in front to prevent colliding with it if it stops; and not pass a signal cleared for the train in front until it has been returned to danger and cleared again.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.4

15. Once a train has come to a stand, under what conditions may a further movement (other than coupling/uncoupling) be made?

Answer: Only if a signal is cleared for the movement, the movement is authorised by the signalling system, or the movement is authorised by the signaller.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.5

16. If a movement is made on the signaller's authority, what must the driver do afterwards?

Answer: Tell the signaller when the movement has been completed.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.5

17. What is the maximum setting-back distance allowed for coupling or uncoupling without the signaller's authority?

Answer: 600 mm (2 feet). A greater distance requires the signaller's authority.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.5

18. When can a permissive movement be made in an emergency?

Answer: When the signaller tells the driver that, in an emergency on a TCB or ERTMS line, the train is authorised to enter an occupied section to use a station platform.

GERT8000-TW1 §20.6

19. Why is caution needed even when an 'OFF' indicator is showing at a permissive platform?

Answer: An 'OFF' indication does not always mean the line ahead is clear — the signal may have been cleared for another train already standing ahead in the same platform (the same caution applies on an ERTMS line without lineside signals where a route has been set).

RS521 §5.8

20. On a bi-directional permissive platform line, what may accompany the 'OFF' indication?

Answer: An 'UP' or 'DN' indication showing which route has been set.

RS521 §5.8

21. What risks does classroom guidance highlight around stopping position on a permissive platform?

Answer: Stopping short risks the rear of the train not being along the platform edge (risk of death or serious injury if doors are opened); overrunning may need a setting-back movement or drawing forward, causing delay; bi-directional platforms increase the risk of conflicting movements — only move with a clear understanding of how the movement is authorised, and stop if unsure.

Classroom PPTX (Permissive Working), slides 9-11

22. If there is doubt whether someone has fallen from a train stopped incorrectly at a platform, what must the driver get before making certain movements?

Answer: The signaller's permission, before making a wrong-direction movement, a movement towards a signal at danger, or any movement on a permissive platform line.

GERT8000-TW1 §39.1

23. What must be confirmed before a controlled test stop is arranged for low rail-adhesion conditions on a permissive-worked line?

Answer: That the platform line is clear.

GERT8000-TW1 §28.3